

Supplementary Tables

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Scope: List all references that constitute the original sources for the VAST display

- Suler, J. (2004). The online disinhibition effect. *CyberPsychology & Behavior*, 7(3), 321–326.
<https://doi.org/10.1089/1094931041291295>
- Stuart, J., & Scott, R. (2021). The Measure of Online Disinhibition (MOD): Assessing perceptions of reductions in restraint in the online environment. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 114, 106534. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2020.106534>

Quotes:

- “people say and do things in cyberspace that they wouldn’t ordinarily say and do in the face-to-face world. They loosen up, feel less restrained, and express themselves more openly.” (Suler, 2004, p. 321)
- “If so desired, people can hide some or all of their identity. They also can alter their identities. As the word “anonymous” indicates, people can have no name or at least not their real name.” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)
- “When people have the opportunity to separate their actions online from their in-person lifestyle and identity, they feel less vulnerable about self-disclosing and acting out. Whatever they say or do can’t be directly linked to the rest of their lives. In a process of dissociation, they don’t have to own their behavior by acknowledging it within the full context of an integrated online/offline identity. The online self becomes a compartmentalized self. In the case of expressed hostilities or other deviant actions, the person can avert responsibility for those behaviors, almost as if superego restrictions and moral cognitive processes have been temporarily suspended from the online psyche. In fact, people might even convince themselves that those online behaviors ‘aren’t me at all.’” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)
- “In the text communication of e-mail, chat, instant messaging, and blogs, people may know a great deal about each other’s identities and lives. However, they still cannot see or hear each other.” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)
- “People don’t have to worry about how they look or sound when they type a message. They don’t have to worry about how others look or sound in response to what they say. Seeing a frown, a shaking head, a sigh, a bored expression, and many other subtle and not so subtle

signs of disapproval or indifference can inhibit what people are willing to express. [...] Avoiding eye contact and face-to-face visibility disinhibits people. Text communication offers a built-in opportunity to keep one's eyes averted.” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)

- *“This invisibility gives people the courage to go places and do things that they otherwise wouldn't” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)*
- *“the Measure of Online Disinhibition (MOD), was developed as a comprehensive and valence free instrument for assessing self-perceptions of psychological and behavioral change in the online as compared to the offline environment.” (Stuart & Scott, 2021, p. 9)*
- *“disinhibition is not always so salutary. We witness rude language, harsh criticisms, anger, hatred, even threats” (Suler, 2004, p. 321)*
- *“At least six factors are involved. For some people, one or two of them produces the lion's share of the disinhibition effect. In most cases, however, these factors intersect and interact with each other, supplement each other, resulting in a more complex, amplified effect.” (Suler, 2004, p. 322)*

Construct Source Table

Reference	Quote	Extracted element (Concept or relationship)	Element type (Concept or Relationship)	Rel. type (n, p, i, r, c, ...)	Short name / associated concept	Comment	ID
Suler (2004, p. 321)	<i>“people say and do things in cyberspace that they wouldn't ordinarily say and do in the face-to-face world. They loosen up, feel less restrained, and express themselves more openly.”</i>	State Disinhibition	C	n	StateDis		A
Suler (2004, p.	<i>“If so desired, people can hide some or all of their identity. They also can alter their</i>	Anonymity	C	n	AN	characteristic of cyberspaces	B

322)	<i>identities. As the word “anonymous” indicates, people can have no name or at least not their real name.”</i>						
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“When people have the opportunity to separate their actions online from their in-person lifestyle and identity, they feel less vulnerable about self-disclosing and acting out. [...] The online self becomes a compartmentalized self.”</i>	Compartmentalized Self	C	n	CS		C
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“In the case of expressed hostilities or other deviant actions, the person can avert responsibility for those behaviors, almost as if superego restrictions and moral cognitive processes have been temporarily suspended from the online psyche. In fact, people might even convince themselves that those online behaviors ‘aren’t me at all.’”</i>	Felt Responsibility	C	n	FR		D1
		Base Responsibility	C	n	base_resp	baseline tendency of an individual to assume responsibility for their actions	D2
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“In a process of dissociation, they don’t have to own their behavior by acknowledging it within the full context of an integrated online/offline identity.”</i>	Dissociative Anonymity	HOC	n	DisAn		E
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“In the text communication of e-mail, chat, instant messaging, and blogs, people may know a great deal about each other’s identities and lives. However, they still cannot see or hear each other.”</i>	Invisibility	C	n	Inv	characteristic of cyberspaces	F

Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“People don’t have to worry about how they look or sound when they type a message. They don’t have to worry about how others look or sound in response to what they say. Seeing a frown, a shaking head, a sigh, a bored expression, and many other subtle and not so subtle signs of disapproval or indifference can inhibit what people are willing to express. [...] Avoiding eye contact and face-to-face visibility disinhibits people. Text communication offers a built-in opportunity to keep one’s eyes averted.”</i>	Interpersonal Cues	C	n	IC		G1
		Concern about impression on others	C	n	CAI		G2
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“This invisibility gives people the courage to go places and do things that they otherwise wouldn’t”</i>	Courage to express oneself	C	n	CE		H
Stuart and Scott (2021, p. 9)	<i>“the Measure of Online Disinhibition (MOD), was developed as a comprehensive and valence free instrument for assessing self-perceptions of psychological and behavioral change in the online as compared to the offline environment.”</i>	Measure of online disinhibition	C	n	MOD	trait online-disinhibition	I
Suler (2004, p. 321)	<i>“disinhibition is not always so salutary. We witness rude language, harsh criticisms, anger, hatred, even threats”</i>	Percentage of curse words	C	n	Curse	Percentage of sentences that contain at least one curse word.	J

						Operationalisation of disinhibited behavior	
Suler (2004, p. 322)	<i>“At least six factors are involved. For some people, one or two of them produces the lion’s share of the disinhibition effect. In most cases, however, these factors intersect and interact with each other, supplement each other, resulting in a more complex, amplified effect.”</i>	Effect of Elements of Cyberspace	R	c	EFF	main effect of each factor and additional interaction effect	K

Variable Table

Construct	Short Name	Scale level	exogen/ endogen	Range/ Values	Anchors
Anonymity	AN	continuous	exogen	[0;1]	0 = User is fully known during the interaction; 1 = Full anonymity where the user remains unknowable during and after the interaction (based on definition by Christie & Dill, 2016) ¹
Compartmentalized Self	CS	continuous	endogen	[0;1]	0 = online- and offline-self are completely identical; 1 = feeling like ‘those online behaviors “aren’t me at all.”’ (Suler, 2004)
Base Responsibility	base_resp	continuous	exogen	[0;1]	mean score for the items of the Accountability Scale (Witvliet et al., 2023) ² , rescaled to the range [0;1] with 0 = “Disagree strongly” to 1 = “Agree strongly”
Felt Responsibility	FR	continuous	endogen	[0;1]	0 = one feels no responsibility for one’s actions, temporary suspension of moral cognitive processes; 1 = maximal feeling of responsibility for one’s actions
Interpersonal cues	IC	continuous	exogen	[0;1]	0 = text-only, minimal interpersonal cues; 1 = audio, video and nonverbal feedback, maximal nonverbal, paraverbal and verbal cues
Concern about impression on others	CAI	continuous	endogen	[0;1]	0 = not concerned about impression on others, 0.3 = mildly concerned about impression on others, 1 = maximally concerned about impression on others

Courage to express oneself	CE	continuous	endogen	[0;1]	0 = maximal inhibition and fear of expressing oneself; 1 = no fear of expressing oneself
Measure of online disinhibition	MOD	continuous	exogen	[1;5]	mean score on a 5-point Likert scale; 1 = “Not at all like me” to 5 = “Very like me” for the items of the MOD (Stuart & Scott, 2021)
State Disinhibition	StateDis	continuous	endogen	[-0.1;1.2] ³	-0.1 = no inclination to “say and do things in cyberspace that they wouldn’t ordinarily say and do in the face-to-face world” (Suler, 2004); 1.2 = maximal inclination toward such behavior
Percentage of curse words	Curse	continuous	endogen	[0;1]	0 = no sentence contains any curse word; 0.5 = half the sentences contain at least one curse word each; 1 = every sentence contains at least one curse word

¹ Christie, C., & Dill, E. (2016). Evaluating peers in cyberspace: The impact of anonymity. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 55, 292–299.

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2015.09.024>

² Witvliet, C. V., Jang, S. J., Johnson, B. R., Evans, C. S., Berry, J. W., Leman, J., Roberts, R. C., Peteet, J., Torrance, A. B., & Hayden, A. N. (2023). Accountability: Construct definition and measurement of a virtue vital to flourishing. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 18(5), 660–673. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2022.2109203>

³ Note: this range was not specified a priori, but is the natural result of the mathematical formula used to compute values for this construct.

Relationships Table

Output variable	Function to compute the output variable	Comment	To what extent derived from theory?^a	To what extent empirically backed?
CS	$CS = (AN^2)/(AN^2 + (1-AN)^2)$	positive, S-shaped relationship	Loosely inspired by theory	indications, but no robust empirical evidence
FR	$FR = \text{base_resp} * (1 - 0.8 * CS)^3$	negative exponential relationship; base responsibility included as model parameter that changes the intercept	Loosely inspired by theory, with added elements based on common sense and other theories	indications, but no robust empirical evidence
CAI	$CAI = IC$	positive linear relationship	Loosely inspired by theory	no evidence for this specific relationship
CE	$CE = -CAI + 1$	negative linear relationship	Loosely inspired by theory	no evidence for this specific relationship
StateDis	$\text{StateDis} = 0.2 * MOD - 0.3 * FR + 0.2 * CE - 0.1 * FE * CE$	psi-function	Loosely inspired by theory, with added elements based on common sense and other theories	no evidence for this specific relationship
Curse	$\text{Curse} = (\text{StateDis} + 0.1)/1.3 + \text{rnorm}(\text{mean} = 0, \text{sd} = 0.1)$	+ rnorm to add random noise/interpersonal variance	Not based on focal theory, but rather on common sense or other theories	no evidence for this specific relationship

^a Response scale:

- Dictated by theory (add IDs from the Construct Source Table as reference)

- Derived from theory
- Loosely inspired by theory
- Not based on focal theory, but rather on common sense or other theories
- Not at all.